

QA INTERVIEW ACCELERATOR

Technical QA Interview Cheat Sheet

Quick-reference definitions and answers for the technical round.

Introduction

A one-page technical refresher to skim before an interview. It covers the definitions and concepts most likely to come up in a QA technical round.

Core Definitions

Term	One-line answer
Verification vs validation	Building it right vs building the right thing
Severity vs priority	Technical impact vs business urgency
Smoke vs regression	Core build check vs "nothing old broke"
Positive vs negative testing	Valid input works vs invalid input handled
Functional vs non-functional	What it does vs how well (performance, security, usability)

Test Design Techniques

- Equivalence partitioning — one value per group of same-behaviour inputs.
- Boundary value analysis — test the edges.
- Decision tables — combinations of conditions.
- State transition — valid/invalid moves between states.

API & HTTP

Code	Meaning
200	OK / success
201	Created
400	Bad request

Code	Meaning
401	Unauthorised
403	Forbidden
404	Not found
500	Server error

SQL Essentials

- SELECT ... FROM ... WHERE ...
- JOIN to combine tables
- COUNT/SUM/AVG aggregates
- Use to verify data and create test data

Automation & AI

- Automate stable, repetitive, high-value checks (regression/smoke).
- Test pyramid: many unit, fewer integration, fewest UI tests.
- AI: draft and assist, never paste sensitive data, always verify and own output.

Common Mistakes

- Guessing instead of saying "I would check/confirm".
- Mixing up severity and priority.
- Claiming tool depth you do not have.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

If you do not know an answer, say how you would find out. "I have not used that, but I would approach it by..." beats bluffing every time.